M.C. Mary Kom's World Championships

Six titles and 2012 Olympic bronze



Boxing has for long been seen as a lesser sport in India and, more crucially, one meant for men. Our first Olympic medal came at Beijing in 2008, and that it came courtesy the beefy six-footer Vijender Singh did no harm to that macho aura of the sport. But after the diminutive M.C. Mary Kom from Manipur let loose her series of punches, even stereotypes were left bleeding. Let's just say being six-time world champion is decent reach for a 5'2" woman, who came back even after maternity to secure a bronze at the London Olympics.

Abhinav Bindra's Shooting Gold

Beijing Olympics, 2008

India has always had a shooting pedigree, but an Olympic medal was elusive until Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore's silver at Athens 2004. It was left to Abhinav Bindra to get history itself in his crosshairs—as the first individual gold medalist ever from India in a tough global arena.





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Neeraj Chopra's Javelin Gold

Tokyo Olympics, 2020

Till Neeraj's gold-encrusted throw of 87.58m in 2020, India's brush with fame in blue-ribbon disciplines was Milkha's 1960 feat at Rome and Anju Bobby George's long jump bronze in 2003 at the Paris World Championships. Neeraj's javelin, flying from Haryana's dusty Panipat to Tokyo glory, humility and grace intact, is one of India's greatest sporting stories ever.

Viswanathan Anand's World Titles

2000 and 2007-2012

The broad consensus deems India to be the home of chess. But that was in another *yuga*. In modern times, it took till the bespectacled Viswanathan Anand single-handedly broke the Russian check before we had anything to talk about. And there's been a lot to talk about since. Three more crowns for Anand, and the many grandmasters, men and women, who ruled the 64 squares in his wake.

